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FREE SPEECHThe idea that misinformation and conspiracy theories spread rapidly on social media is not new, but the challenge for policymakers to do something about it took on a new sense of urgency after the Jan. 6, 2021 insurrection at the U.S. Capitol. In California, one effort was Assembly Bill 587, introduced by Assemblymember Jesse Gabriel, D-San Fernando Valley, seeking to require social media companies to publicly disclose their content moderation policies regarding hate speech, disinformation, extremism and more, as well as key metrics and data regarding how and when they enforce such policies. Social media companies fought back with a major lobbying effort, but a year-and-a-half later, on Sept. 13, Gov. Gavin Newsom signed AB 587 into law. "California will not stand by as social media is weaponized to spread hate and disinformation that threaten our communities and foundational values as a country," Newsom said in a statement. The new law will create unprecedented visibility into how Big Tech operates when it comes to policing its own platforms, and when it does and does not enforce policies meant to protect users from potentially dangerous and harmful content.

QUOTE OF THE WEEK"We're supremely confident right now." - Monterey Bay F.C. midfielder James Murphy, speaking after a 5-0 victory against the Indy Eleven on Saturday, Sept. 17. The team remains in the running for the playoffs. (see story at mcweekly.com)

GOOD WEEK / GREAT WEEKGOOD:Sand City's long-brewing South of Tioga project – just south of Tioga Avenue and east of Highway 1 – is one step closer to becoming reality. The project, which the City Council approved in 2018, has finally cleared its last hurdle, getting a green light from the California Department of Fish & Wildlife to move forward. DFW is satisfied with the city's promises about protecting environmentally sensitive habitat in the sand dunes along the highway. As a result, the last building on the 10-acre property is coming down this week, paving the way for the site to be graded for the construction of a hotel and two apartment buildings. In the coming weeks, developers will finally be able to install underground utilities and grade and pave the site to facilitate future construction. "[It's] one step in the right direction of Sand City providing much-needed housing," City Manager Vibeke Norgaard says.GREAT:Congratulations to the city of Gonzales, one of 12 cities in California to receive the Helen Putnam Award for Excellence in the category of Engaging Youth in City Government. (A total of 155 projects were submitted.) The League of California Cities announced the 2022 winners on Sept. 8. The award recognizes the Gonzales Youth Council, founded in 2015, for engaging kids and teens in civic processes and giving them a space to develop leadership skills. During the pandemic the group launched Youth Supporting Youth, a mental health project where kids and teens worked with professionals to create and conduct a survey. The project brought to light the severity of mental health challenges residents were facing during shelter-in-place and it brought change: the city and Gonzales Unified School District provided funds to hire a second clinical social worker to support students.

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